

Absolutely — **drift** is a strong polysemy target because your passage uses it here:

> “The aroma of freshly baked bread was **drifting** out onto the street...”

Here **drift** means **to move slowly and gently through the air without a strong or controlled direction**. But the word also has important meanings involving **water movement, aimless movement, gradual change, loss of focus, snow/sand accumulation, overall meaning, and controlled car sliding**.

Word family: **drift / drifting / drifter**

Base word: drift

Verb forms: drift, drifts, drifted, drifting

Noun: drift

Related noun: drifter

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞)

Meaning in your passage: **drift = move slowly and gently through the air — 飄 ; 緩緩飄動**

Your sentence:

> “The aroma of freshly baked bread was **drifting** out onto the street.”

Here **drift** means:

> **to move slowly and gently through the air, carried naturally rather than moving under deliberate control.**

繁體中文 :

在空氣中受氣流等自然力量帶動 , 緩慢、輕柔地移動 ; 飄散、飄動

Natural translation:

> “The aroma of freshly baked bread was drifting out onto the street.”

「新鮮出爐麵包的香氣正**緩緩飄到街上**。」

So here:

> **drift = 在空氣中自然地緩緩飄動 / 飄散**

1. **drift = move slowly through the air — 飄動 ; 飄散**

This is your exact source sense.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The aroma was **drifting** out onto the street.”

「香氣正**緩緩飄到街上**。」

Practice 2

> “Music **drifted** through the open window.”

「音樂聲從打開的窗戶**悠悠飄進來**。」

Practice 3

> “Smoke drifted across the room.”

「煙霧在房間裡**緩緩飄過**。」

****drift = 聲音、煙霧、氣味等在空氣中自然、緩慢地移動****

2. ****drift = move slowly on water, carried by current/wind — 漂流；漂動****

A core literal meaning.

Practice 4

> “The boat **drifted** across the lake.”

「小船在湖面上**漂流**。」

Practice 5

> “The leaves drifted downstream.”

「樹葉順流**漂下去**。」

****drift = 物體在水上主要受水流或風推動，沒有主動控制方向地移動****

3. ****drift = move without a clear destination — 漫無目的地移動；遊蕩****

A broader movement sense.

Practice 6

> “People ****drifted**** around the market.”

「人們在市場裡****漫無目的地走動****。」

Practice 7

> “He drifted from café to café all afternoon.”

「他整個下午在不同咖啡店之間****閒晃****。」

****drift = 沒有明確目的地或計劃地慢慢移動****

This is the human-motion extension of passive physical drifting.

4. ****drift = gradually move into a different state/situation — 逐漸進入；慢慢變成****

A major figurative meaning.

Practice 8

> “The conversation ****drifted**** into silence.”

「談話慢慢****變成沉默****。」

Practice 9

> “The town gradually drifted into decline.”

「這座小鎮逐漸****走向衰落****。」

****drift = 沒有明確決定或突然轉折地，逐步進入另一種狀態****

Often implies:

> change happened passively rather than deliberately.

5. ****drift = gradually move away from an original position/idea — 逐漸偏離****

A very important figurative sense.

Practice 10

> “The discussion began to **drift away from** the main topic.”

「討論開始**偏離主要話題**。」

Practice 11

> “The project has drifted away from its original purpose.”

「這個項目已逐漸**偏離原本目的**。」

****drift = 沒有明顯察覺地慢慢偏離原先方向、目標、立場或標準****

This is highly useful in:

- * meetings
- * projects
- * policy
- * academic discussion

6. ****drift = lose concentration / attention moves elsewhere — 走神；注意力飄走****

A common mental extension.

Practice 12

> “My attention **drifted** during the lecture.”

「上課期間我的注意力開始**飄走 / 走神**。」

Practice 13

> “Her thoughts drifted back to childhood.”

「她的思緒慢慢**飄回童年**。」

****drift — mental = 注意力、思緒或記憶不受控制地慢慢移向另一個對象****

7. **drift = gradual movement/change over time — 漂移；逐步變化**

Now as a noun.

Practice 14

> “There has been a gradual **drift** toward online shopping.”

「人們正逐漸**轉向 / 傾向**網上購物。」

Practice 15

> “The policy shows a slow drift away from its original goals.”

「這項政策顯示出慢慢**偏離原定目標的趨勢**。」

****drift — noun = 某種方向、立場或狀況隨時間逐步改變的過程****

8. **drift = general tendency / direction of change — 趨勢；走向**

Closely related to #7.

Practice 16

> “The general **drift** of public opinion was clear.”

「公眾意見的整體**走向 / 趨勢**很明顯。」

Practice 17

> “The drift in consumer habits is difficult to ignore.”

「消費習慣的**變化趨勢**很難忽視。」

****drift = 一段時間內事情整體發展的方向****

I would merge this conceptually with gradual change rather than over-split.

9. **drift = general meaning / main point — 大意；主要意思**

A genuinely distinct noun meaning.

Practice 18

> “I didn’t understand every word, but I got the **drift**.”

「我不是每個字都明白，但我掌握了**大意**。」

Practice 19

> “The drift of his argument was easy to follow.”

「他的論點**大意 / 主要方向**很容易理解。」

****drift = 一段說話、文章或論證的整體意思 / 主旨****

Common expression:

> ****get the drift****

10. ****get the drift = 明白大意；懂我的意思****

A very common idiom.

Practice 20

> “You get the **drift**.”

「你應該**懂我的意思**。」

Practice 21

> “I didn’t explain every detail, but she got the drift.”

「我沒有解釋所有細節，但她已經**明白大概意思**。」

****get the drift = 不需要知道所有細節，也能理解主要意思 / 暗示****

Idiomatic, so best kept in the expression layer.

11. ****drift = pile of snow/sand formed by wind — 積雪；沙堆****

A major physical noun sense.

Practice 22

> “The road was blocked by deep snow ****drifts****.”

「道路被厚厚的****風吹積雪 / 雪堆****堵住。」

Practice 23

> “Sand drifts formed beside the fence.”

「圍欄旁形成了幾個****風吹形成的沙堆****。」

****drift = 由風吹動並堆積形成的一堆雪、沙等鬆散物質****

12. ****snowdrift = 風吹積雪；雪堆****

A useful compound.

Practice 24

> “The car was trapped in a ****snowdrift****.”

「汽車陷在一大堆****風吹積雪****中。」

Practice 25

> “Snowdrifts covered parts of the road.”

「部分道路被****風吹形成的雪堆****覆蓋。」

****snowdrift = 風把雪吹到某處堆積而成的大雪堆****

13. ****continental drift = 大陸漂移****

A major scientific compound.

Practice 26

> “****Continental drift**** changed the positions of the continents over geological time.”

「****大陸漂移****在地質年代中改變了各大陸的位置。」

Practice 27

> “Early evidence for continental drift came from matching coastlines.”

「早期支持**大陸漂移**的證據之一來自彼此吻合的海岸線。」

continental drift = 大陸在地質時間尺度上相對移動的現象

Technical/geological.

14. **drift = controlled sideways movement of a car — 漂移；甩尾**

A common automotive/motorsport meaning.

Practice 28

> “The driver **drifted** the car around the corner.”

「駕駛者讓汽車在彎位**漂移 / 甩尾**。」

Practice 29

> “Drifting requires careful control of the car.”

「汽車**漂移**需要精準控制。」

drift — driving = 讓車輪部分失去抓地力，使車輛以側滑方式通過彎道

This can be:

* motorsport technique

* uncontrolled sliding in other contexts

But deliberate **drifting** is a specific driving technique.

15. **drifter = person who moves from place to place without settling — 漂泊者；流浪者**

A useful family extension.

Practice 30

> “He lived for years as a **drifter**.”

「他多年來一直過著**漂泊者**的生活。」

Practice 31

> “The character is a lonely drifter with no permanent home.”

「這個角色是一個沒有固定居所的孤獨**漂泊者**。」

****drifter** = 沒有固定住所、工作或生活方向，經常從一處移到另一處的人**

Often suggests:

* lack of roots

* lack of long-term plan

16. ****drifter** = person without clear direction in life — 沒有明確人生方向的人**

A figurative extension.

Practice 32

> “He felt like a ****drifter**** after leaving university.”

「大學畢業後，他覺得自己像個**沒有方向、四處漂泊的人**。」

Practice 33

> “The novel follows a young drifter searching for purpose.”

「小說講述一名年輕**漂泊者**尋找人生方向的故事。」

****drifter** = 生活缺乏固定目標 / 方向、隨環境而走的人**

Important distinction: ****drift vs float****

You curated ****float**** earlier.

****float****

emphasizes:

> being supported by water/air without sinking.

drift

emphasizes:

> being carried slowly by wind/current without control.

> “The leaf floats on the water.”

= 葉子浮在水面。

> “The leaf drifts downstream.”

= 葉子隨水流漂向下游。

So:

> float = 浮著

> drift = 被自然力量帶著漂走

Important distinction: **drift vs glide**

You already mapped **glide**.

glide

= move smoothly and gracefully, often controlled.

drift

= move slowly without clear control/direction.

> swan glides across lake

> = 天鵝優雅滑過湖面

> empty boat drifts across lake

> = 空船隨水漂動

Control is the key nuance.

Important distinction: **drift vs wander**

wander

usually describes a person/animal moving without a fixed route.

drift

suggests an even more passive, effortless movement.

> wander through town

> = 在城裡漫步 / 閒逛

> drift through town

> = 悠悠地、沒有明確目的地走過城鎮

****Drift**** often feels less deliberate.

Important distinction: ****drift vs flow****

flow

= liquid/gas moves continuously in a direction.

drift

= an object/smell/smoke is carried slowly by that movement.

> river flows downstream

> = 河水向下游流

> leaves drift downstream

> = 葉子隨水漂流

Important distinction: ****drift vs spread****

spread

= extend over a wider area.

drift

= move gently from one place to another.

Your source:

> aroma **drifted out onto the street**

emphasizes **movement**.

If:

> aroma **spread through the street**

it emphasizes **covering a larger area**.

Important distinction: **drift vs waft**

waft

= be carried gently through air, especially smell/smoke/sound.

drift

= broader; applies to air, water, people, ideas, attention, etc.

For your bakery sentence:

> aroma drifted out

> and

> aroma wafted out

are both natural.

****Waft**** is more specifically atmospheric and often slightly literary.

Important distinction: **drift vs slide**

You already mapped ****slide****.

slide

= smooth movement while usually contacting a surface.

drift

= movement without fixed direction/control, often through air/water.

> car slides on ice

> = 車在冰上滑

> boat drifts on water

> = 船在水上漂

In motorsport, **drift** develops its own specialized car-sliding meaning.

Important distinction: **drift into** vs **choose to enter**

drift into

= gradually enter a situation without deliberate decision.

choose to

= deliberately decide.

> “He drifted into the profession.”

= 他沒有明確計劃，慢慢就進入了這個行業。

> “He chose to enter the profession.”

= 他有意決定進入這個行業。

This agency difference is important.

Important distinction: **drift away from a topic** vs **change the topic**

drift away

= topic gradually changes unintentionally.

change the topic

= someone deliberately introduces a new subject.

> “The conversation drifted away from business.”

= 談話不知不覺偏離了生意話題。

Much more passive.

Important distinction: **attention drifts vs lose concentration**

They are close.

attention drifts

= attention gradually wanders elsewhere.

lose concentration

= stop concentrating.

Drift gives a more gradual, involuntary image.

Important distinction: **drift — movement vs trend**

Physical:

> “Smoke drifted across the room.”

= 煙霧緩緩飄過。

Abstract:

> “There is a drift toward online shopping.”

= 出現逐漸轉向網購的趨勢。

Same conceptual core:

> slow movement in a direction.

Important distinction: **drift — trend vs direction**

direction

can be intentional or neutral.

drift

often suggests gradual, not fully controlled movement.

> policy direction

> = 政策方向

> policy drift

> = 政策逐漸偏離 / 慢慢改變

So **drift** often carries a sense of weak control.

Important distinction: **drift = main meaning**

This is quite different from all the movement senses.

> “I get your drift.”

Here **drift** means:

> 大意 / 真正想表達的方向

It does **not** mean physical movement.

This is one of the strongest MCQ contrasts.

Important distinction: **drift vs current**

current

= movement of water/air itself.

drift

= movement of an object caused by current/wind, or the resulting displacement.

> ocean current

> = 洋流

> boat drift
> = 船的漂移

Important distinction: **drift — driving vs skid**

skid

= vehicle slides uncontrollably because tyres lose grip.

drift

in motorsport:

= intentionally maintain controlled sideways sliding.

So:

> skid = 打滑，通常失控
> drift = 漂移，作為技術時通常受控

Important distinction: **drifter vs traveller**

traveller

= someone who travels.

drifter

= someone moving from place to place without stable roots or clear long-term direction.

Drifter carries a much stronger lifestyle implication.

Family-extension sweep

After the full audit, the useful modern family includes:

* **drift — air** = 緩緩飄動 / 飄散

* **drift — water** = 漂流

* **drift — aimless movement** = 漫無目的移動

* **drift into a state** = 逐漸進入某狀態

* **drift away from** = 逐漸偏離

* **attention/thoughts drift** = 走神 / 思緒飄移
 * **drift — gradual change** = 漂移 / 逐步變化
 * **drift — trend** = 趨勢 / 走向
 * **drift — general meaning** = 大意 / 主旨
 * **get the drift** = 明白大意
 * **snow/sand drift** = 風吹積雪 / 沙堆
 * **snowdrift** = 雪堆
 * **continental drift** = 大陸漂移
 * **drift — driving** = 漂移 / 甩尾
 * **drifter — literal lifestyle** = 漂泊者
 * **drifter — figurative** = 缺乏生活方向的人

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
drift — air	受氣流等自然力量帶動，在空氣中緩慢輕柔地移動
drift — water	主要受水流 / 風推動，在水面上沒有主動控制地漂流
drift — aimless movement	沒有明確目的地或計劃地慢慢移動
drift into	沒有明確決定地逐漸進入另一種狀態
drift away from	不知不覺逐步偏離原本方向、目標或話題
attention/thoughts drift	注意力 / 思緒不受控制地慢慢移向別處
drift — gradual change	某狀況、立場或方向隨時間逐步改變的過程
drift — trend	一段時間內事情整體發展的方向 / 趨勢
drift — meaning	說話、文章或論證的整體意思 / 大意
snow/sand drift	由風吹動並堆積形成的雪堆 / 沙堆
continental drift	大陸在地質時間尺度上相對移動的現象
drift — driving	車輪部分失去抓地力、車輛以受控側滑方式過彎
drifter	沒有固定住所 / 生活方向而經常四處移動的人

For your original sentence

> “The aroma of freshly baked bread was **drifting out onto the street** ...”

The exact meaning is:

**drifting = 麵包香氣不是突然大量湧出，而是隨著空氣慢慢、自然地從店內飄散到街上。 **

Natural translation:

> **「新鮮出爐麵包的香氣正緩緩飄到街上。」 **

The highest-value contrasts are:

- > ****smoke drifts through the air**** → 煙霧緩緩飄動
- > ****boat drifts downstream**** → 船隨水漂流
- > ****drift around town**** → 漫無目的地閒逛
- > ****drift into silence**** → 逐漸陷入沉默
- > ****drift away from the topic**** → 逐漸偏離話題
- > ****attention drifts**** → 走神
- > ****a drift toward something**** → 逐漸轉向某事的趨勢
- > ****get the drift**** → 明白大意
- > ****snowdrift**** → 風吹積雪
- > ****continental drift**** → 大陸漂移
- > ****car drift**** → 汽車漂移 / 甩尾